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Simon the sorcerer

The magician of Samaria who tried to buy the power of the Holy Ghost.

Simon was the most famous man in Samaria. For a long time he had amazed the people with sorcery, and they called him "the great power of God." Then Philip came preaching Christ, with real signs and healings. The crowds turned to Jesus, and Simon himself believed and was baptized. He followed Philip everywhere, amazed at the miracles. But when Peter and John arrived and the Holy Ghost was given through the laying on of their hands, Simon offered them money for the same power. Peter's rebuke was sharp: God's gift cannot be bought. Simon asked the apostles to pray for him, and there the story ends. His name lives on in the word "simony," the buying or selling of church offices and spiritual things.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	Greek <i>Simon</i> , from the Hebrew Simeon, "hearing." Later called Simon Magus, "Simon the magician"
<i>Family</i>	Not given
<i>Known as</i>	"The great power of God," to the Samaritans (Acts 8:10)
<i>When</i>	c. AD 33–35, soon after Stephen's death
<i>Key places</i>	A city of Samaria
<i>Key people</i>	Philip the evangelist; Peter; John the apostle
<i>Main passages</i>	Acts 8:9–24
<i>New Testament</i>	Named only in Acts 8

"Thy money perish with thee, because thou hast thought that the gift of God may be purchased with money."

Acts 8:20, KJV

The life of Simon the sorcerer

Dates are approximate (AD). The events follow the scattering after Stephen's death, c. AD 33–35. Acts does not tell us what became of Simon.

Before Philip comes Samaria	Amazes the people
	For a long time Simon uses sorcery and bewitches the people of Samaria. He claims to be "some great one," and everyone from the least to the greatest listens to him. <i>Acts 8:9–11</i>
c. AD 33–35 Samaria	Believes and is baptized
	Philip preaches the kingdom of God and the name of Jesus Christ. Men and women believe and are baptized, and Simon himself believes too. He stays close to Philip, amazed at the signs. <i>Acts 8:12–13</i>
Samaria	Watches the apostles
	The church in Jerusalem sends Peter and John. They pray for the Samaritans and lay hands on them, and the believers receive the Holy Ghost. Simon sees it happen. <i>Acts 8:14–18</i>
Samaria	Offers money
	Simon offers the apostles money, saying, "Give me also this power, that on whomsoever I lay hands, he may receive the Holy Ghost." <i>Acts 8:18–19</i>
Samaria	Rebuked and asks for prayer
	Peter tells him his heart is not right before God and calls him to repent. Simon answers, "Pray ye to the Lord for me, that none of these things which ye have spoken come upon me." <i>Acts 8:20–24</i>

Group notes

Key activities

Christians differ on whether Simon's faith was real. Some think he was a true but immature believer who sinned badly. Others think his faith was only on the surface, because Peter says his heart was "not right in the sight of God." Acts leaves the question open.

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- 1 **Practised sorcery.** He "used sorcery, and bewitched the people of Samaria, giving out that himself was some great one." *Acts 8:9*
 - 2 **Believed and was baptized.** "Then Simon himself believed also: and when he was baptized, he continued with Philip." *Acts 8:13*
 - 3 **Tried to buy spiritual power.** Seeing the Holy Ghost given, he offered the apostles money. *Acts 8:18-19*
 - 4 **Heard a hard rebuke.** Peter said, "Thou hast neither part nor lot in this matter: for thy heart is not right in the sight of God." *Acts 8:20-21*
 - 5 **Was called to repent.** Peter urged him to repent and pray, for he was "in the gall of bitterness, and in the bond of iniquity." *Acts 8:22-23*
 - 6 **Asked for prayer.** He asked the apostles to pray for him. Acts does not say what happened next. *Acts 8:24*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Simon.

Old Testament

Deuteronomy 18:10–12	The law forbids witchcraft and enchantments
Deuteronomy 29:18	"Gall and wormwood," behind Peter's phrase
Echo: 2 Kings 5:20–27	Gehazi tries to profit from God's healing
Echo: Isaiah 55:1	Buy "without money and without price"

New Testament

Acts 8:9–24	The only account of Simon
Echo: Matthew 10:8	"Freely ye have received, freely give"
Echo: Acts 13:6–12	Paul confronts the sorcerer Elymas
Tradition	Later writers tied him to Gnosticism; these stories grew over time

For discussion

1.

Observe: What did Simon see that made him offer money (Acts 8:18–19)?
2.

Understand: What did Simon misunderstand about God's gifts?
3.

Apply: Where are you tempted to use faith to gain attention or status?
4.

Apply: Who could you ask to pray for you this week about a struggle you face?

Group notes